

The UPA retains power. It's a vote for stability.

Meira Kumar is elected the first woman Speaker.

Finally a strong home minister; no major terror attacks in 2009.

The young and savvy Mohanrao Bhagwat becomes the RSS chief.

Fifty-nine women MPs, the highest since Independence.

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Manmohan and Advani fight a bitter, personalised E-2009.

Liberhan report proves the collapse of credibility of such commissions.

Politics of hate takes over with the rise of Raj Thackeray's MNS.

Former CM Madhu Koda is charged in a Rs 2,000-crore scam.

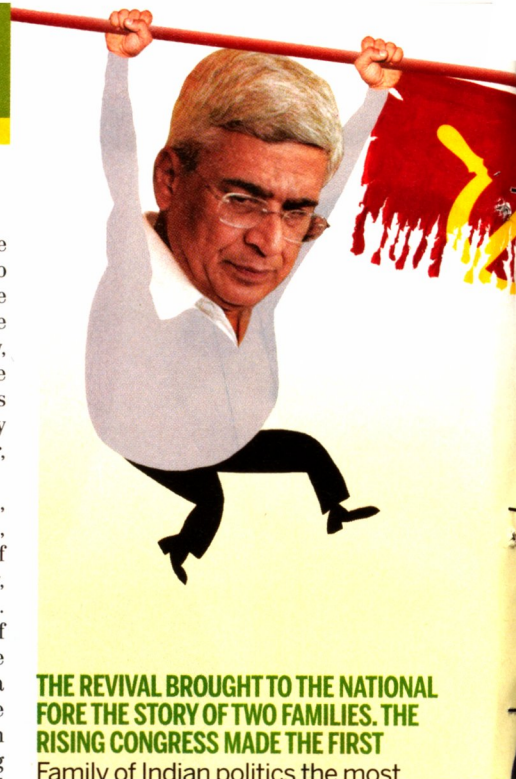
N.D. Tiwari resigns as governor after a sex scandal.



originally the least political of them all, quite reassuring—Doctor Most Dutiful, not only to the Family that employed him but to the electorate too? The truth was that the Congress won, though not magisterially, without much of a fight. Power didn't provoke the ruling party to script slogans of delusions either. What made the victory seemingly effortless was the pathology of its challenger, the moribund BJP.

It was the year in which the Indian Right, which swayed the mind of India a decade ago, repudiated itself. It was the political story of intercellular disintegration in which ideology, biology and history played equal parts. Campaign 2009, in retrospect, was a face-off between superannuated fantasy and anodyne realism. At 82, it was at last Lal Krishna Advani's Number One moment, and he, the veteran charioteer who once drove through the heart of the political Hindu, was waiting for it. After a lifetime in the existential backyard of the Number Two, the destination looked graspable, and it was an amazing show of ambition as the long distance traveller of Indian politics portrayed himself as future. He led a presidential style campaign; he turned it into a referendum on himself. He was the "strong" leader, the "determined" leader, pitted against India's "weakest" prime minister.

Something didn't connect, and strangely, Advani, whose public life is inseparable from the political evolution of independent India, failed to sense it. As he gave himself to the last pleasures of delusion, the space that naturally belonged to the Right was shrinking around him. The year 2009 could have been his had he chosen to be not the warrior but the charioteer. He should have been the patron saint of renewal; he ended up as the tallest symbol of decay. He should have been the master of transition, passing the mantle to the best of the next generation. Advani was the tragedian of 2009, and his story overshadowed his party's. Set against the Right in denial, the Congress looked soaring. It was the context of stagnation that gave the Congress's text an aura of the surge. In reality, only Rahul Gandhi, the reluctant heir who wants to rebuild the kingdom before the inevitable coronation, can claim the title of the reviver. By daring to go alone in Uttar Pradesh, the state that once nurtured the



THE REVIVAL BROUGHT TO THE NATIONAL FORE THE STORY OF TWO FAMILIES. THE RISING CONGRESS MADE THE FIRST

Family of Indian politics the most influential extra-constitutional power centre in a democracy. The other family, the moribund House of Saffron, failed to provide the counterpoint. It has to update its family values to remain relevant in the 21st century India.

political invincibility of his ancestry, the chief campaigner of the Congress succeeded in regaining a bit of the lost sheen.

Elsewhere, be it Andhra Pradesh or Maharashtra, the Congress victory in the Assembly elections was a popular endorsement of strong local leadership or good governance. In Maharashtra, the glory was hardly singular; the power of alliance—read Sharad Pawar—and the fragility of the Opposition made it easier for the Congress to retain the state. The Congress didn't conquer; its regional performers did not let the mandate slip away. And everywhere, the defeat of a disintegrating opposition was bigger than the victory itself. It is the power of the rejoinder that makes democracy work. In 2009, the mind of the Indian opposition was too blank to ask questions, to challenge the status quo. Mayawati remained as unshakable as any of those statues that loom over Lucknow, and that was mostly because the me-alone diva of the BSP continued to renew the sociology of empowerment. The Opposition—the SP or the BJP or the